

| By Dilip Bobb |

Forget those images of ravaged villagers, kids with distended bellies and ragged clothes and a future as grim as the cracked, sun-baked earth. Islands of poverty still exist but most of rural India is transformed beyond imagination thanks to a host of factors which has put unprecedented wealth into the hands of farmers across the country and turned it into a huge consumer market. Latest statistics show that agricultural growth and rural income has largely been unaffected by the economic slowdown, this, despite the fact that the contribution of agriculture to total rural income has actually come down. Instead, we have a growing service industry and alternate revenue channels from horticulture, poultry, fisheries and other activities which are less rain-dependant and were virtually non-existent a decade ago. India's 6,38,000 villages, which harbour 72.2 per cent of the population, once the albatross around its neck, are now the signpost to its future.

Call it a new adventurism or entrepreneurship, but most farmers have gained from a switch to new crops and technology, like Sunil Katkade from Naygaon, a small village in Nashik district. Initially, he grew rain-fed crops like bajra and wheat which was barely enough to feed his family. Four years ago, he installed a micro sprinkler irrigation system and switched to vegetable farming. He also tied up with an exporter who guarantees purchase of his output at a preset price. Today, he earns Rs 6 lakh a year. Rising food

